In 1600, Elizabeth I had granted a charter to a group of 218 men, the Governor and Company of Merchants trading to the East Indies[†], allowing them a trade monopoly with the 'East' for fifteen years, and giving them the right to wage war where necessary. Unlike their competitors, the Dutch, the Portuguese, and the French, this small group of unprepossessing merchants would prove to be spectacularly successful in extending these original powers into something so vast it would make of England, at the time a somewhat underwhelming, insignificant power, the greatest empire on earth in a couple of centuries. As historian William Dalrymple describes it:

> Over the next 200 years [the EIC] would slowly learn to operate skilfully within the Mughal system and to do so in the Mughal idiom, with its officials learning good Persian, the correct court etiquette, the art of bribing the right officials, and, in time, outmanoeuvring all their rivals…for imperial favour.

With the crumbling of Mughal power in the eighteenth century, and after Nadir Shah's coup de grâce in 1739, it would no longer be imperial favour that the EIC would court, but imperial power.

But in 1605 the Mughal Padshah was entirely unconcerned with the doings of his inconsequential English guests. Well pleased with Asad Beg's fine selection of unusual and eclectic souvenirs from the Deccan, Akbar directed him to return to Bijapur, Golconda, Bidar, and the Carnatic with instructions to search specifically for rare elephants and jewels. 'You must not relax your efforts,' clarified the Padshah, 'as long as there is one fine elephant or rare jewel out of your grasp in the Dakhin.' Before leaving, Akbar told Asad Beg to stay on a while at the court to enjoy the fine spectacle of elephant fights he had ordered. But Asad Beg declined the invitation and left the court, a decision for which he was later very grateful, for the elephant fight would trigger violence during which subterranean channels of jealousy and hate would erupt spectacularly.

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*Steel bows were an Indian invention—less flexible than the composite bow, but more durable, and not prone to warping and splitting in India's hot and humid climate.

*This also, not inconsequentially, led to England being released from Papal edicts forbidding trade with Muslim nations.

†The East India Company was founded in 1599.